

PANKAJ TIWARI



House Full

70* DELHI	2003 Contested 40 Won 0 Vote 5.76%
200 RAJASTHAN	2008 Contesting 70
230 MADHYA PRADESH	2003 Contested 124 Won 2 Vote 3.97%
2008 Contesting 200	
230 MADHYA PRADESH	2003 Contested 157 Won 2 Vote 7.26%
2008 Contesting 230	
90 CHHATTISGARH	2003 Contested 54 Won 2 Vote 4.45%
2008 Contesting 90	

* Seats at stake in the state assemblies

seats. It led in 55 of the state's 80 parliamentary segments and the Mayawati camp believes that the party can do similarly well in another 60 seats outside the state. The ongoing elections will gauge if the Maya-Marx friendship can walk the talk. The Red brigade has called upon its cadre to vote for BSP candidates in all constituencies where Left candidates are not contesting. For a cadre-based party like the CPI(M), dealing with individual-centric party like the BSP may prove difficult. The party also fears that due to its alliance with the BSP, it will end up losing its residual cadre to the bigger partner. Hence the CPI(M) has given clear directions to its cadre not to be part of any campaign for BSP candidates. But the Left is also not sure about the longevity of its alliance with the BSP, given that Mayawati's

dalliances with the BJP and the Congress were unilaterally called off by the unpredictable party supremo.

The twin states of Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh also hold special significance for the BSP, historically as well as electorally. It was in undivided Madhya Pradesh that the party's late supremo Kanshi Ram entered the electoral arena for the first time in 1984 from Janjgir constituency in Chhattisgarh. Though he won just 9 per cent of the vote, India's fastest growing political outfit was born. Since then, the party's fortunes have fluctuated, however: in the last Assembly elections, it could win only two seats from each state.

In the 2003 assembly polls, the BSP got 7.26 per cent of the vote share in Madhya Pradesh as against 6.3 per cent five years earlier. The reason for

its electoral breakthroughs in Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh lay in its successful social engineering even before the recent wooing of the upper castes in Uttar Pradesh.

In Rajasthan, the party will contest all 200 assembly seats and all prominent castes have found equal representation. The party had won two of the 124 seats it contested in 2003, raking in 3.97 per cent of the overall vote. With the BSP in the fray, many argue that the ride for the Congress will get a lot rougher. The BSP's thrust on a rainbow coalition can also wean away the BJP's traditional upper caste votes. Though the BSP may make headway in terms of vote share, the overall picture is not rosy for the party. Mayawati will find it difficult to translate an increasing vote share into seats.

The BSP is squeezed between two major political parties. Its votes are spread across seats and get divided. The contest is divided sharply between the BJP and the Congress," says Sudha Pai, political analyst at Jawaharlal Nehru University. What will come on the BSP's way in the ongoing elections is the fact that the elections are fought mostly on local development issues where voters are not likely to fret much over issues of identity and *swabhiman* (pride). The politics in all four heartland states that are going to elections are still bipolar and the BSP would find it difficult to extend its support base with its limited options for forming alliances.

It is symptomatic of the nature of the party's leadership that the BSP remains the only party not to have released its own poll manifesto. "The performance of Mayawati Government in Uttar Pradesh is our manifesto," says a party functionary. The BSP is looking for flashes of recognition in its journey to Race Course Road. If it fails, the elephant is likely to remain tethered in the backyards of Uttar Pradesh.

with inputs from Ambresh Mishra and Rohit Parihar